

A Thin Veiled Night

The Nail Box

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EXT. FREEMANSBURG FLATS / LOCK 44 - NIGHT

Cedar sticks wait on a stone ring between Main Street and the canal. Lock 44 sits quiet. The locktender house keeps a stone face and an aluminum roof gone dull like old tin. The towpath still carries the curve of mule work in the dirt. Once the sun drops behind the South Mountain ridge, wind rides up the bank off the Lehigh.

COLE BACHMAN (32) sits close to the heat. A maple tray rests under one of his boots. Across the ring a few faces wait with sticks and coffee cups.

COLE (V.O.)

Hand me that dry cedar. The wind off the Lehigh is coming up the bank the way it always does once the sun drops, and I want this fire high enough to keep the canal damp from settling in your coats. My name is Cole Bachman. I'm thirty-two. This is about the nail box I found in my father's garage three weeks after we buried him, and about what his cut list left me to do with my hands.

Cole feeds cedar into the coals until the flame climbs. River smell and wet leaves ride the air. Two blocks over, somebody's leaf pile still smokes.

COLE (V.O.)

Frank Bachman framed houses and hung doors from Bethlehem Township out past Hellertown until his shoulders quit. After that he took porch rails and kitchen cabinets and the kind of repair a man can still do when the bone spurs start talking. He lived in a brick half-double on Main Street with the canal behind the back fence. He died on a Tuesday in September. Rita and I cleared the house through the first two weekends of October. She took the kitchen and

the upstairs closets. I took the garage.

CUT TO:

INT. FRANK'S GARAGE / MAIN STREET - DAY

Cinder-block walls Frank poured himself in '89. A steel door that sticks when August gets mean. Along the north wall, a workbench still dented where his elbows used to rest.

Oil stains on the concrete map the ghost of a Ford that left in 2011. Cobwebs run from the fluorescent tube down to the pegboard. On the second shelf a coffee can of mixed bolts sits with its lid pushed half flat. In the dust under the bench a carpenter's pencil stub lies chewed at one end the way Frank chewed when he was thinking about a joint.

Cole opens the door and stands in the threshold a moment before he steps inside.

Last night's rain left a dark stripe along the canal-facing block. Cole takes a push broom to that stripe before he lays a hand on any shelf. The broom knocks a Vernors bottle cap loose. He boots the cap toward the open door and keeps the broom moving.

Beyond the chain-link a woman walks a beagle along the empty towpath. The dog pauses at the fence post Frank used to brace open when he stained shutters.

Cole works the easy shelves first: paint cans, a garden hose still kinked from its last wind, and two boxes of Christmas lights Rita wants for her porch. The ballast above him hums and clicks. His shoulders are still tight from the burial week and the cold cuts in the kitchen, so the garage gives his arms a job that does not need his mouth.

He pulls leftover trim down from the far pegs. Paint has chipped white along the edges. Back of that pile, on a dusty high shelf, he finds a wooden tray: hinged lid, six compartments.

Maple, darkened by oil and years of palms. Frank's block print on the lid in black Sharpie: CUT LIST INSIDE. KEEP SQUARE.

Cole sets the tray on the bench and thumbs the latch hook free.

Four bays hold what a finish man keeps: sixteen-penny commons, eight-penny finishes, a scatter of wide-head roofing nails, and one clean empty slot with bare wood at the bottom. Under the nails, folded to the tray's size, rests a softcover Gospel of John, the pocket kind churches hand out free, corners worn white. Frank's margins are packed the way he marked cut lists on OSB before any blade touched wood.

Cole takes the stool with the garage door open and gray canal light coming in, and he turns pages.

INSERT - GOSPEL MARGINS

At a Sabbath healing mark, block print: MY FATHER / NOT OUR / EQUAL CLAIM / CHECK JOINT.

At another: I AM / BEFORE THE BOARD WAS LAID.

At a unity mark: SAME STOCK / SQUARE TRUE OR THROW THE STICK.

At a way-and-truth mark: NO BYPASS / ONLY RUN.

Beside Thomas: ACCEPT OR REJECT / NO MIDDLE KERF.

BACK TO SCENE

Frank printed a short list on the blank inside back cover, same block hand he used when he laid out cabinet parts:

CLAIM: GOD

IF LIE: LIAR

IF MAD: LUNATIC

IF TRUE: LORD

GOOD TEACHER = BAD JOINT

NO 4TH CUT

Cole keeps the book open on the maple while water moves slow behind the fence. A runner in a yellow jacket passes on the towpath. Across the river toward Bethlehem a train horn sounds once. At John 1 a grease thumbprint sits dark and old in the bottom corner.

He tucks the Gospel under the nails again, closes the lid, and finishes sorting for the morning.

INT. HALF-DOUBLE KITCHEN - DAY (LUNCH)

RITA wraps plates in newspaper. Cole stands with a mug of coffee.

COLE

Dad left a marked John in his nail
box.

Rita presses her lips tight and goes back to the plates. She is already crying enough for both of them over Mom's old baking pans.

EXT. HALF-DOUBLE DRIVEWAY / GARAGE - DAY (SATURDAY)

DEREK backs a truck into the drive. MANNY shows up with gloves and a six-pack he parks in a cooler on the porch, because Rita has kept beer out of the house since Frank's heart.

They move leftover lumber, a table saw freckled with rust on the throat plate, and a cast-iron vise heavy as a small engine. Cole's lower back complains about that vise the whole way down the driveway.

When daylight fails and the heavy work is done, Derek points toward the canal bank.

DEREK

We ought to build a fire down
there the way we used to in high
school.

Rita says fine if they stay inside the ring and leave the neighbor's fence alone. Cole brings the nail box with him. He still has not decided what to do with it, and he will not leave it alone on that bench overnight.

EXT. CANAL BANK / FIRE RING NEAR LOCK 44 - DUSK

They light scrap pine from Frank's pile with a sheet of Morning Call. Across the water the lock house stays dark. Porch bulbs on Main Street come on one by one. Manny runs a hot dog on a bent hanger. Derek parks on an overturned five-gallon bucket and cracks a can. Up the bank a moth circles the nearest porch bulb and keeps bumping the glass.

COLE (V.O.)

Derek is a good man with a framing
nailer and a kid in Tee Ball. He
goes to a church in Bethlehem when
his wife makes him, and he likes
Jesus the way a lot of men like
Jesus, which is to say he likes
the parts about being kind and he
skips the parts where Jesus talks
like God.

DEREK

Your dad was a straight one.

He tips the can at the maple tray by Cole's boot.

DEREK (CONT'D)

Built my sister's deck and
wouldn't take the tip.

COLE

He was.

DEREK

What's in the fancy box?

Cole opens the lid. The Gospel rests on the nails. Derek lifts the book, thumbs a few pages, and laughs once through his nose.

DEREK (CONT'D)

Cut list in a Bible. That's Frank.

COLE

Read the back cover.

Derek reads every line Frank printed on that back cover, including the good-teacher line. He shuts the book and leaves it on his knee. A knot pops in the fire and throws a spark onto the ring stone, where it dies.

DEREK

I don't buy that. Jesus was a good teacher. Best one. Doesn't mean He was God. Buddhists have teachers. Muslims have a prophet. You don't have to make the man into the Maker to take the good from Him.

Manny keeps his eyes on the coals and turns the hot dog. Rita has gone back up to check a casserole for Sunday. Mud and autumn hang over the canal. Under the far bank a duck makes a low sound.

Out of the maple tray he draws Frank's old Starrett combination square, blade scratched, level vial cloudy at one edge. From the woodpile he takes a foot of clear pine scrap and sets it across his knees.

COLE

Hand me that pencil.

Derek tosses the carpenter's pencil from his shirt pocket. Cole catches it and turns the scrap. In Frank's block hand he prints one word on each face: LIAR, then LUNATIC, then LORD. On the soft fourth face Derek prefers, he prints TEACHER.

He sets the square to the LIAR face and reads it the way you read a stud for plumb before you commit a nail. The blade sits and the vial settles. He turns the scrap to

LUNATIC and reads it again. The vial stays quiet the same way. He turns it to TEACHER.

COLE (CONT'D)

Here's your fourth cut.

He lays the square on that face. The blade rocks on a high corner Cole left last summer when he planed this scrap for another job and never trued it. The vial refuses to settle. Derek watches Cole's hands on the tool.

DEREK

That's just a bad edge.

He reaches into the cooler for another can without getting up.

COLE

It is. So was calling Him only a teacher. The man didn't leave that edge square. He claimed the Name. He claimed the forever. He took worship from Thomas and didn't correct him. You keep teacher on that claim and the joint opens in a year.

Cole rolls the scrap to LORD and seats the square again. Flush. The vial goes still over ordinary pine.

Derek drinks. Manny pulls the hot dog off the hanger and blows on it. Across the canal, on the Bethlehem side, a second-story window lights and then goes dark.

DEREK

You're doing a trick with a board.

He holds the Gospel out toward Cole.

COLE

I'm doing what Dad did with that Gospel. He didn't write me a lecture. He wrote me a cut list. Claims first. Then the only cuts that keep the wall standing.

Cole parks the square on his thigh. He lifts a sixteen-penny common from the tray and seats the point on LORD. The framing hammer from the garage takes three hits. The nail goes through the scrap into a short block he planted in the dirt for this.

Frank's chalk reel comes out next, red plastic, crank worn smooth. Cole snaps a clean red mark over the top of the scrap above the nail, same habit Frank used on a wall plate before the plates went down. The powder smells like chalk always smells. The mark runs true over LORD and dies at each edge.

Cole's hands finish it. He puts the Gospel back in the empty bay, lays the square beside the nails, and sets the chalk reel on top. He shuts the maple lid and works the hook until it clicks. He leaves the scrap with the nail through LORD standing in the dirt by the ring.

Derek empties his can and crushes it on the bucket rim.

DEREK

I still think He was a teacher.

Derek looks from the scrap to the closed tray and on to the lock house across the black water.

COLE

I know. I'm not your Holy Spirit.

Manny laughs soft and tosses his stick into the coals. Rita comes down the bank carrying cookies and asks why they look like a union meeting. Nobody gives her the long version. They eat. The fire goes to a red bed. Derek talks Tee Ball scores and a coach who cannot tell a force play from a hole in the ground. Cole keeps one hand on the tray on the bucket lid and checks the latch with his thumb now and then.

INT. HALF-DOUBLE / FRANK'S RECLINER - NIGHT

Cole sleeps in Frank's old recliner because Rita has the guest bed. The half-double ticks as the heat kicks off and the pipes settle.

Around two he wakes sure he heard Lock 44 working at night, the low wooden shove of a gate and water climbing the chamber. He gets up in socks and checks the back window.

The chamber is empty and the gates hold still, with streetlight flat on the water and a plastic grocery bag snagged on the mule barn fence fluttering without a sound.

Cole stands with his forehead near the glass.

COLE (V.O.)

I did not decide whether I had
heard a boat that wasn't there or
a house settling or a father who'd
left me a cut list and then gone
ahead through a door I can't see
yet. The veil gets thin in a canal
town if you let a night get quiet
enough. I don't pretend I know
which side of the veil made the
sound.

EXT. HALF-DOUBLE DRIVEWAY - MORNING

In the morning Cole walks the maple tray out to his truck and parks it on the passenger floor mat. Rita follows with coffee in two travel mugs.

RITA

What are you keeping from the
garage.

COLE

Dad's cut list.

He rests his palm on the lid so she can see he means the whole tray. She does not ask him to explain. She kisses his cheek, tells him to come back for the casserole leftovers, and stands in the driveway in Frank's old flannel while he turns the key.

INT/EXT. COLE'S TRUCK / ROUTE 412 - DAY

Cole climbs out of Freemansburg toward Route 412. Near the old grist mill remains the maple tray slides once on the turn. His right hand finds the lid until the tray holds still, and he leaves that hand there through the light at the bottom of the hill.

CUT TO:

EXT. FREEMANSBURG FLATS / LOCK 44 - NIGHT (GROWN CODA / BACK TO FRAME)

Cole (present) builds the fire higher. The lock house stays dark. Cedar pops. The Lehigh moves past toward Easton in the dark. The maple tray sits closed by his boot.

COLE (V.O.)

I still take that box to jobs. I don't open it for every man on a crew. Some men aren't ready for a cut list that costs them their favorite soft answer. When a man like Derek starts in about a good teacher and only a good teacher, I don't give him a campus lecture. I hand him a square and a scrap and I let his own hands find out whether the fourth cut sits true. Most of the time he laughs and goes back to his nailer. Once in a while he gets quiet, and the quiet does more work than my talk ever did.

He keeps the tray shut by his boot and watches the fire.

COLE (V.O.)

Dad's Gospel of John still sits in that empty compartment under the chalk line, and the block print hasn't faded: CLAIM: GOD / NO 4TH CUT. I am not here to close the big question for you. I am here to tell you what a dead carpenter wrote in the margins of John, and what his living son did with a

square and a nail when a friend
tried to keep a bad joint in the
wall.

Cole looks at the unspent cedar on the stone ring.

COLE (V.O.)

Throw that other piece on. Let it
catch. I like a Freemansburg fire
that shows me the towpath and the
faces both, and leaves the canal
black where the light can't reach.

FADE OUT.